

River Art Works

Executive Summary

Client

Jane Altman

Student Consulting Team

Ana Fontán

Eunice Lee

Preeya Kirani

Background

River Art Works is a nonprofit organization founded in 2018 and based in Westmoreland County, Pennsylvania. The organization plays a key role in supporting artists and creative initiatives in a region with limited artistic infrastructure. Its mission is to “cultivate creativity, facilitate collaborations, educate creatives, and harmonize artistic tradition with creative technology.”

Despite operating with a small budget and no full-time staff, River Art Works manages multiple programs, including the Greater Westmoreland Arts Coalition (GWAC). However, the organization faced challenges related to fragmented systems, manual processes, and an underdeveloped digital presence. These limitations restricted its ability to support artists, engage the community, and generate sustainable revenue. This project focused on strengthening River Art Works’ digital infrastructure to improve visibility, streamline operations, and support long-term growth.

Project Description

Project Opportunity

The Greater Westmoreland Arts Coalition (GWAC) website presented a significant opportunity to strengthen River Art Works' digital presence and revenue-generating capabilities. At the time, the site suffered from three core issues: its visual identity was inconsistent with the River Art Works brand, its navigation deterred user engagement, and most critically, its artist directory was entirely non-functional. Without a working directory, artists had no structured channel for visibility, and River Art Works had no mechanism to generate membership revenue. The project addressed these gaps by redesigning the site's visual identity, building a functional tiered artist directory, and establishing the administrative infrastructure needed for Jane to independently manage the platform going forward.

Project Vision

The project aimed to redesign and rebuild the GWAC website into a dynamic, user-friendly platform that supports artists, engages visitors, and enables sustainable revenue generation. The solution prioritized usability, automation, and long-term sustainability, enabling the client to independently manage the system without technical expertise.

Project Outcomes

This project successfully transformed the organization’s digital infrastructure, moving from a disorganized manual state to an automated, scalable platform that directly supports the mission of increasing artist visibility.

- **Technology:** The team rebuilt the website to modernize GWAC's visual identity and implemented a searchable directory (0% error rate) and a tiered registration portal (100% accuracy). A secure GiveButter payment system was integrated, allowing centralized revenue tracking.
- **Process:** Administrative processing time was reduced by 90%, decreasing tasks from approximately 30 minutes to under 3 minutes. Manual workflows were replaced with structured, automated processes.
- **People:** The client transitioned from technical dependency to independent management of site content, directory listings, and sponsorships. Users now benefit from an intuitive, self-service platform to discover local artists.
- **Sustainability and Risks:** The solution is supported through a comprehensive Handoff Guide and training. However, long-term sustainability depends on maintaining plugin subscriptions and system configurations (e.g., Google Cloud), creating a "Free Kittens" scenario requiring ongoing oversight.

Project Deliverables

The project produced a comprehensive set of deliverables designed for both immediate use and long-term sustainability:

- **GWAC WordPress Website:** Fully redesigned platform with integrated artist directory, registration forms, and automated workflows
- **Handover Document:** Step-by-step guide for site maintenance and independent management
- **External Google Account:** Dedicated account to support system operations
- **Meeting Notes and Agendas:** Documentation of decisions and project progress
- **Supplementary Technical Documents:** Code snippets and directory taxonomy for future development

Recommendations

To build on the success of this project, the following recommendations are proposed:

- **Mobile Optimization:** Improve the mobile user experience to increase accessibility and engagement.
- **Automated Payment Integration:** Integrate payment processing directly into the registration workflow to eliminate manual verification and improve efficiency.
- **Standardized Data Review Protocol:** Implement a structured approval and auditing process to maintain data consistency and preserve directory quality over time.

These recommendations focus on improving usability, efficiency, and long-term sustainability.

Student Consulting Team

Eunice Lee is a senior majoring in Information Systems, based in NYC. She worked as the technical lead of the project. Eunice is looking forward to graduating from Carnegie Mellon University.

Preeya Kirani is a junior studying Information Systems and AI. She served as the team's junior developer and client deliverable manager, ensuring client-facing deliverables met Jane's requirements and developing three website pages.

Ana Fontán is a junior studying Information Systems. She worked as a junior developer and class deliverable manager. Ana is interested in pursuing a career in Cybersecurity.